

SCAFFOLD

SUPPORTS TERTIARY HOW

FOR WHY-WHAT · WHAT-WHY

The Effort Reality-Check

A structured correction for the chronic underestimation of execution effort. **The estimate gets built from tasks and history**, not from optimism.

THE DRAIN

Estimation lives in the HOW orientation: it requires seeing all the tasks, including the invisible ones. Tertiary HOW profiles estimate from the shape of the work, which reliably misses reviews, revisions, coordination, and cleanup, and the shortfall lands as missed deadlines and weekend recoveries.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The worksheet forces the estimate through a sequence that surfaces the invisible work. Every task gets listed and sized, the standard hidden categories get added explicitly, and the total gets compared against a real past project before a multiplier is applied. The output is a number you can defend.

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 Never estimate from the shape.** If the tasks are not listed, the estimate is not real yet.
- 2 Do the history comparison out loud.** Saying "the last one took double" makes the multiplier undeniable.
- 3 Present the corrected number first.** Anchor on reality; let others argue it down explicitly if they choose to.
- 4 Log actuals when it ends.** Every completed project sharpens your personal multiplier.

The correction sequence

- | | |
|---------------------------------|---|
| 1 List every task | Use the decomposition worksheet. Estimates on unlisted work are fiction. |
| 2 Size each one | Small, half-day, full-day. Rough is fine; complete is mandatory. |
| 3 Add the invisible work | Reviews, revisions, approvals, coordination, cleanup. It is never zero. |
| 4 Compare to history | Find one comparable past project. What did it actually take? |
| 5 Apply the multiplier | Whatever ratio history shows, apply it. The pattern is more honest than the plan. |

WHAT IT WON'T DO

This corrects structural underestimation; it cannot price genuinely novel work where no history exists. In those cases the honest output is a range with named unknowns, and the worksheet will at least make the unknowns explicit.

IN THE KIT

Reality-check worksheet

Invisible work checklist

Actuals log

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 1 Vision-to-Task Decomposition · **Tool 15** Milestone Backplanning · **Tool 10** HOW-Partner Review Protocol